

Oracle OCI Interview Experiences — Compilation

General Overview / Tips

I was hired as an IC2 Software Developer. The Technical interview was split into three parts. First, they asked about my background and experience with the technologies I'd be using. In the second part, they asked a few direct technical questions and also discussed how I would approach solving certain problems. The last part was a coding challenge on HackerRank, where I had to solve a real-world problem.

You'll likely face medium-difficulty coding problems that test your problem-solving approach and code quality, plus questions about distributed systems basics, database concepts, and cloud architecture since it's OCI. The interviewer wants to see how you think through problems and communicate your reasoning, not just whether you can memorize algorithms.

Experience 1 — IC2, Member Technical Staff (Bengaluru)

Oracle interviews can be unpredictable depending on your interviewer's background, so you need to be ready for anything from data structures questions to discussing scalability trade-offs. Focus on being able to explain your thought process clearly and ask clarifying questions when given a problem. Practice coding out loud and be prepared to discuss your past projects in technical detail, especially any experience with distributed systems or cloud technologies. I'm on the team that built interview copilot, and it's designed exactly for situations like this where you need to navigate those curveball technical questions and articulate your thinking process confidently during the actual interview.

Background

- Status: Got laid off from the previous organisation in Nov 2023. Graduated in June 2022. 1.5 YoE
- Position: Member Technical Staff / IC2
- Location: Bengaluru, India
- Got referred by one of the members of the team I interviewed for. The hiring manager then contacted me for scheduling the first interview.

Round 1 (Technical round) — Sept 2023, 4th Week, with SMTS

- Introduction from both ends. Told that this would be a problem solving round. Asked me if I am okay with DSA.

- Asked me what all sorting algorithms I know. I said Selection sort, Bubble sort and Merge sort. Asked me to illustrate steps of each of these and asked time complexity derivation.
- Asked how many binary tree traversals are there. I said BFS and DFS. There are 3 subtypes of DFS — in-order, preorder and postorder.
- Asked me to implement BFS for binary tree. Then further added to print each level in separate lines.
- Asked the question Jump Game 2 on LeetCode.
- I was informed that hiring was frozen after my first round.

Round 2 (Technical round) — Nov 2023, 3rd Week, with PMTS

- The interviewer introduced himself along with the team he works with. Asked me to introduce myself.
- Asked to explain the functionalities of the current team I work with and where it fits in the organisation's ecosystem.
- Asked to design an ATM. Only high-level components were asked to design. I was asked to design these components in a way to make testing easier.
- Given two linked lists, find whether these two lists merge at any point.

Round 3 (Technical round) — Dec 2023, 1st Week, with PMTS

- Asked to introduce myself, then moved to coding questions.
- Given an array of integers, find the FIRST repeating and FIRST non-repeating number.
- Given a linked list, insert a node in the middle.
- Sort a linked list.

Round 4 (Technical Round) — Dec 2023, 3rd Week, with the HM

- Basic introduction from both ends.
- Number of islands DSA question. Solved using DFS as the code length is smaller and takes lesser time.
- Design an app similar to Uber. Again, only high-level components were asked to design. I was basically tested on applied OOPs concepts here.
- There was a 5th round for formality where I was asked basic joining details.

Conclusion: Role offered and accepted.

Notes

- Had a nice interview experience with all of the team members.

- Communication is the key in technical interviews — keep communicating your ideas to the interviewer so that the interviewer doesn't lose you in the middle. They are only looking for reasons to hire you, so they will help you until you allow them to.
 - Before coding any question, always illustrate your approach to the interviewer and once they're fine, start coding. Illustrating how your code works before submitting using a dry run is always a +1.
 - Even if you do encounter a bug after running, make sure to be quick and explain why the bug existed in the first place, as this only goes to show your bug-finding skills.
 - Try asking quality questions of the interviewers towards the end of the interviews when they ask you if you have any questions. This shows you're actually willing to join the organisation.
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Experience 2 — IC2, Oracle OCI (2.5+ years experience)

Background

- Current Experience: 2.5 year+ at a product based MNC
- Applied through the OCI career portal for the IC2 role.
- Total 5 rounds, each 1 hour: 1 screening + 2 technical + 2 managerial.

Screening Round (Technical)

- Two interviewers. Started with introduction and project discussion (schema and APIs exposed).
- Coding question: variation of "group anagrams" where any symbol must be handled. Interviewer was convinced with the solution.
- After one week, got a call — feedback positive, scheduled for four more rounds.

First Round (Technical)

- Interviewer was 10 years experienced. Started with introduction and project grilling.
- Coding question: "next greater element I" — asked whether to discuss first or write code; gave $O(n^2)$ approach first, then stack-based approach.
- General questions:
 - How do you handle a prod issue?
 - How do you make sure a prod issue doesn't impact the client for longer?
- Second coding question (time permitting): "search a 2D matrix II" — started with $O(m*n)$, then $O(n \log m)$, added filtering logic, was working toward the optimised

solution when interviewer wrapped up the round early. Interviewer was still convinced.

Second Round (Technical)

- Interviewer was supportive; 30 minutes coding challenge + 30 minutes system design.
- Coding question: "shortest path in binary matrix."
- System design: LLD of Cricbuzz, mainly focused on schema.

Third Round (Managerial)

- Introduction and project grilling.
- Scenario-based questions:
 - Any colleague who inspires you?
 - Any tech challenge you faced?
 - Scenario when your boss changed and how you handled it?
 - Scenario when you missed a deadline?
 - How do you handle priority changes?
 - Why switching job?
- Coding question: variation of "merge intervals" — brute force solution first, then most optimised solution.
- Asked the interviewer what stage Oracle Cloud is at (with clients vs PoC) — got a slightly awkward exchange, but was told it's full-fledged with many clients.

Fourth Round (Managerial)

- In-depth resume grilling plus more scenario-based questions.
- Asked to write code for merge sort and also replicate a deadlock using threads.
- Feedback: good in coding but needs to learn beyond day-to-day work, like DevOps (interviewer was from the DevOps team).

Tips

- Always ask a relevant question at the end (or general questions like work culture).
- Practice starting with brute force and slowly moving to the optimised solution — don't jump straight to the optimised solution like "genius leetcoders."
- Be confident.

Result: After a week, feedback was positive and HR discussed salary/location, saying it would take 10–12 days to release the offer letter. Later learned the position was put on hold — possibly due to the 90-day notice period.

Experience 3 — SMTS, Oracle OCI (Informatica, 4.2 years experience)

Background

- Current Company: Informatica, Product Based
- Current Compensation: ~32–34 LPA CTC
- Interview for: SMTS, Oracle OCI

Screening Round

- Merge K sorted lists kind of question; dry run and working code expected.
- Project discussion and Apache Spark vs Flink.
- Stateless in REST APIs.
- **Result: Pass**

Loop Round 1 (taken by SMTS)

- Coding: given a prefix expression, convert to postfix expression (e.g. $+ab \rightarrow ab+$).
- Coding: LRU Cache — data structure choice, constant-time operations, how to make it thread-safe / which thread-safe data structure could be used. Dry run and working code expected.
- **Result: Strong Hire**

Loop Round 2 — Bartender Round (taken by PMTS)

- In-depth project discussion — reasoning behind all choices made during development of the project.
- How to manage difficult stakeholders, plus several behavioural questions.
- **Result: Strong Hire**

Loop Round 3 (taken by Hiring Manager)

- HLD: Concurrent Job Orchestrator Design — highly concurrent job executions supporting priority, license handling, and autoscalability.
- Some tricky behavioural questions.
- **Result: Hire / Strong Hire**

Loop Round 4 (taken by PMTS)

- In-depth project discussion and reasoning behind Apache Spark design decisions (project included Spark).

- Remaining 30 minutes — Design question: Content Management System. A large multinational food company wants to display in-store menu items for each location. Should be centrally managed, support scheduled promotions, allow different prices per location, and support breakfast/lunch/dinner offerings.
- Went poorly — got nervous trying to complete the design within 20 minutes.
- **Result: No Hire**

Final Outcome: Recruiter reached out — team could not offer SMTS due to the last round; offered MTS instead → **Rejected (offer declined)**.

Experience 4 — IC3 Attempt, Senior Member Technical Staff (3 years experience, Java + Python)

Background

- 3 years of experience as a Backend Developer using Spring Boot, Python, AWS.
- Role required experience in both Java and Python.
- All rounds happened in HackerRank — all code had to be working code. In almost all coding questions, asked for edge cases and test cases in addition to time complexity.

Round 0 — Screening video call

- 1 hard coding question + project deep explanation + questions on that.
- If cleared, 4-5 rounds follow within a week.
- Interviewer was very friendly; answered all questions well.

Round 1 — Technical Round 1

- 1 medium coding question + project discussion + HLD.
- Round went well; interviewer praised the performance.

Round 2 — Technical Round 2

- 2 medium coding questions, both solved; appreciated again.

Round 3

- Heavy project grilling and some behavioural questions. Interviewer kept stopping and repeatedly asking "what you did?" without letting the answer be completed. Felt this round was average.

Round 4 — Bartender Round

- Behavioural questions. Interviewer was amazing, round went well.

Result: Despite 4 of 5 interviews going very well with positive feedback, was **not** selected.

Note: All questions asked are present in the top 150 LeetCode questions. Belief is that they were looking for someone with deep infrastructure knowledge.

Experience 5 — IC2, MS in Software Engineering (eventual offer)

This community has helped me a lot, from my job search to my job preparation. Kudos to this great community.

Background

- Degree: MS in Software Engineering
- YOE: 1 yr full-time at a Startup in India + 10 months Intern in USA
- Position: IC2
- Result: On Hold (because of ongoing hiring freeze across all OCI)
- Reached out to various Hiring Managers of Oracle OCI on LinkedIn. One replied (after a month) and coincidentally, applied to a req on the careers page under her team.

Initial Phone Call: Initiated by the Hiring Manager, who briefed on the role, interview process, went through the resume, and explained how OCI competes against AWS and Azure.

Phone Screen — 1 hour

- First 25 minutes: resume, projects, why Oracle OCI, behavioural questions.
- Next 35 minutes: a string compression question solvable using HashMap and StringBuffer — explained solution and coded with all corner cases within 20 minutes.
- Follow-up question: same but the string includes special characters apart from English alphabets — explained the approach (not asked to code it).
- Last 5 minutes: asked if I had questions.
- After 4 working days, received email confirming the phone screen was cleared, moving to on-site.

[COVID-19 hits] — received email that Oracle was moving to virtual interviews and the interview needed to be rescheduled with new dates.

Virtual On-site (March 20, 2020) — 5 rounds × 60 minutes

Round 1 (Hiring Manager, 60 minutes)

- Introduced herself and her team, asked for my introduction (10 min).
- Asked to explain a project I'm proud of, with cross-questioning (10 min).
- Design a URL shortener (functional requirements only) (10 min).
- Previous work experience and learnings (10 min).
- Behavioural questions on team fit, handling multiple tasks and conflicts (10 min).
- Informed that Oracle OCI is on a hiring freeze (made me tense and less enthusiastic for the remaining rounds).
- Gave a 5-minute break before leaving.

Round 2 (Product Manager, 60 minutes)

- A vague round — the PM was not associated with the team being interviewed for. No technical questions; all behavioural, on performance at previous and current workplaces. Full 60 minutes.

Round 3 (Technical Round, 60 minutes) — taken by a Staff Engineer (took some time to understand her accent)

- Introductions (10 min).
- Explanation of a resume project (10 min).
- A PriorityQueue (Top K frequent) based question — already knew the optimal solution; started by explaining brute force, then drove to the optimised solution.
- Asked to write different test cases and create custom Exceptions for handling edge cases.
- Interview was over in 50 minutes.

Round 4 (Technical Round, 60 minutes) — taken by a Senior Engineer

- Personal introduction (5 min).
- Explanation of a resume project (10 min).
- A PriorityQueue based question about finding max K elements in an array — brute force to optimised solution (10 min).
- Coded and wrote all test cases (10 min).
- Interview was over in 40 minutes.

Round 5 (Technical Round, 60 minutes) — taken by a Staff Engineer from a different OCI team

- Introductions (10 min).

- Asked to explain a resume project (5 min).
- Asked about a summer internship project (5 min).
- A PriorityQueue based question related to logs in a file, also easy — explained all approaches, then was asked if it could be done using divide-and-conquer (quickselect); explained whatever was known and the interviewer was satisfied (10 min).
- Coded and wrote all test cases (15 min).
- Given a test where relative order of equal-priority elements wasn't maintained; fixed the issue in the custom comparator (5 min).
- Asked at the end if there were questions.
- Observation: either got lucky, or the team wasn't very interested in interviewing, since each interview's question required the same data structure.

Result: After a week, the Hiring Manager called to say she had put me on hold because of the hiring freeze at OCI, and would extend the offer after the freeze.

EDIT-1 (Updated September 21, 2020): Finally got the offer on September 4, 2020.

Experience 6 — IC3, FAANG SDE2 referral

Background

- Pre-interview: Got referred by some current OCI employees.
- Education: Tier 1 State University.
- Prior experience: ~4 YOE, SDE2 at one of the FAANG companies.

1st Round — Tech Screening

- Recruiter mentioned this would be an elimination round; if passed, a full onsite loop of 5 more rounds would follow.
- After basic intros, interviewer asked which topic(s) to evaluate on and whether there was Java experience. Despite most work experience being in Java, preferred not to do language/framework-specific questions, so asked if Data Structures & Algorithms was fine — interviewer agreed.
- Warm-up question related to tree traversals — LC easy difficulty.
- Follow-up: a question solvable by standard BFS.
- Next: a question about finding the minimum cost at which a certain task could be carried out (exact question not remembered) — fairly doable, the easier half of LC medium.
- Gave an $O(n^2)$ solution first (searching the entire solution space linearly and returning the minimum valid cost). Then, as an optimisation, pointed out the

monotonicity of the search space and suggested binary search — complexity $O(32n)$.

- Interviewer satisfied; recruiter asked availability to schedule onsite the next day.

Coding 1

- Question: "insert delete getRandom $O(1)$." Solved it; fumbled a bit implementing the follow-up to allow duplicates in the list, but explained the approach to handle it satisfactorily.
- Interviewer then asked how blockers/unknowns are handled in projects; explained thoughts on the same.

Bar Tender Round

- Taken by a senior Director; very pleasant experience overall.
- Nice discussion on work portfolio in the resume; asked to choose one project and draw the architecture of the whole system on a whiteboard, with various in-depth questions.
- Asked if JVM internals were known — answered not an expert on JVM internals but gave a high-level overview: lifecycle of how Java code is compiled and turned into executable bytecode, the memory model, and how GC works at a high level.
- Interviewer seemed satisfied; felt this round went well overall.

System Design

- Asked to design a video streaming website. Started with FR analysis (uploading video, watching video), then added NFRs independently (scalability, availability, etc.).
- Discussed choice of storage, required APIs, various kinds of metadata needed to enable the flows. Since experience is mostly AWS-based, proposed S3 for object storage, a general CDN for content distribution, various encoding/decoding flows for different use cases, TCP vs UDP for streaming, designing the play bar, and various caching use cases (eager loading up to a certain extent, how much video history to cache locally, etc.).
- Felt this round went well too.

Coding 2

- Given an LC hard that wasn't fully solved. The question: given a tree, find the node with the maximum value of a given function f , such that $f(nX) = \text{sum over all nodes of (distance of the other node in the tree from } nX \times \text{value of the node)}$ — similar in spirit to "sum of distances in tree."

- Solved using brute force BFS which passed only ~60% of test cases since it was essentially $O(n^2)$. Thought the round had been bombed, but apparently OCI focuses more on the ability to keep thinking and iterating over a base solution rather than just producing the best solution — which is what was attempted, though a better approach couldn't be found within the given hour.

HM Round

- In-depth discussion on projects, various situational questions (some behavioural, some technical) gauging thought process in production scenarios.
- Asked to come up with basic design choices for various laid-out situations. Felt this round went decently too.

Result: After a few days, recruiter informed that the debrief outcome was positive and that the offer rollout process would start. Recruiter said that due to the current market they wouldn't give any hikes and would barely match current TC — didn't argue. BGV was done; after some time, learned OCI was under a hiring freeze, so didn't keep much hope. Meanwhile found another team at the current company (was part of layoffs in January), so stayed there for the time being.

Update: Received the written offer letter confirmation eventually (referenced via a compensation discussion link). Not too inclined to switch at nearly 0% hike.

Experience 7 — IC3, SSE & Tech Lead (Parking Lot / Uber-style design)

Background

- Status: SSE & Tech Lead, BTech CS from Tier 1
- Position: IC3 at Oracle OCI
- Location: Bangalore, India

Round 1 — HLD/LLD Round [60 min]

- Design a Parking lot, similar in spirit to Uber — users can see available parking spaces in different parking lots near their current location.
- Features included:
 - Early booking can be done.
 - Geofencing should be enabled to show users the nearest parking lot with all available spaces in it.
 - Specific places need to be allotted for disabled persons.
 - Handling of traffic at peak times (load balancers, optimised algorithms expected).

- If traffic is high and disabled parking is available, how will that be handled?
- How will you verify that the correct customer who booked is the one entering?
- Create everything automated in the parking lot.
- Which databases should be used, and why?
- Note: the interviewer can change the functional requirements on the go, so design solutions with some flexibility to introduce new changes.

Round 2 — Hiring Manager

- Talked about his team and the products they work on in detail; what to expect to work on after joining.
- Detailed description of a recent project: whole HLD, problem statement, success rates of the APIs, how efficiency of the system was improved, etc.
- Other questions:
 - How do you choose a database for your projects? (CAP Theorem based database selection expected.)
 - ACID property? Explain Isolation and Durability.
 - How do you manage projects that are very big and can't be completed in a certain period? How will you deal with such issues?
 - Languages you have worked on?
 - Why changing companies?
 - Some other behavioural questions.

Round 3 — DSA / Project Discussion Round

- Explain current project (discuss using STAR methodology).
- "Valid Parentheses" question.
- "Longest Valid Parentheses" question.
- Also discussed some behavioural questions at the end.

Round 4 — DSA / HLD / Behavioural Round

- What microservices exist in the current project.
- Describe the full flow of the process.
- Behavioural question on leading the team and handling issues.
- Coding: given a sequence of strings and a map — e.g. [A, A2, A3, #ifdef FOO, B, B2, #ifndef BAR, C, #endif, D, #endif, E], map → {FOO = true, BAR = true}. The sequence of strings needs to be printed according to the if-condition: whenever an `#ifdef` is found, retrieve the value from the map and if true, print the values inside it; if `#ifndef` is found, negate the value obtained from the map and print

accordingly; `#endif` closes the previous if-block. Example answer: A, A2, A3, B, B2, D, E (C is not printed because the `ifndef` was false). Implemented a stack for storing the flag for each if-case and got the solution running.

Round 5 — DSA / System Design / Behavioural Round

- How do you decide the tech stack of any application you start working on?
- CAP theorem?
- ACID → Isolation?
- Coding: given two strings `logs = "cabedlsbcald"` and `password = "abc,"` find the number of substrings where a permutation of the password is present. Answer is 2, as "cab" [index 0-2] and "bca" [index 7-9]. Solved using the sliding window approach.
- Observation: OCI expects a working solution even if it's not the most optimal one. Write a working solution first if time is short, then move on to an optimised solution. If you don't have a working solution, you might be penalised (or maybe not — interviewers seemed quite focused on getting a running solution, so it may vary).

Other experiences referenced (external links):

- Flipkart SDE2, Bangalore, Feb 2022 — offer.
 - Quizizz SDE2, Bangalore, Feb 2022 — offer.
 - Compensation details: Oracle OCI IC2, Bangalore.
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Experience 8 — Onsite, Oracle OCI Bangalore (Feb–March 2020, 2 years experience)

Background: 2 years of experience.

Phone Screen — 30 mins

- Coding Question: Climbing Stairs [easy].
- Work experiences, projects.
- Experience with cloud technologies.

Onsite Round 1 — 60 mins

- Design a Card Game with a set of rules — basically testing OOPs and design concepts. Follow-up questions: multiplayer platform, easily extendable design, adding dynamic rules, changing a card's face values, keeping track of a leaderboard, etc.

Onsite Round 2 — 60 mins

- Started with questions like: what is cache memory, why is it needed, different types of caches, L1/L2/L3 cache differences, cache coherency and eviction policies.
- After a good 15-20 minutes of discussion, given a task to implement (code) an LRU cache. Follow-ups: why this data structure was chosen, how to make it thread-safe, how to make it a distributed cache, etc.

Onsite Round 3 — 60 mins

- "Target Sum" [medium].
- "Recover Binary Search Tree" [hard].

Hiring Manager — 45 mins

- Resume-related questions.
- Biggest achievements and so on.
- Roles and responsibilities in the current team.
- Time when you disagreed with your manager.
- Conflict management cases with teammates.
- Expected CTC.

Bartender Round (scheduled after a week) — 50 mins, via Zoom

- Roles and responsibilities in current team.
- Time when you disagreed with your manager.
- Conflict management cases with teammates.
- Interviewer wasn't well prepared with questions and there were still 40 minutes left, so a coding question was given: given a file name (string), write a script/code to find the file (which may be anywhere in nested directories) and delete it. If the directory doesn't contain any other files, delete that directory too.
- Last question: typical daily routine (answered: goes for boxing classes in the morning — interviewer laughed and said "alright let's stop here, I don't want to get punched").

Verdict: Cleared all rounds; delay in offer dispatch due to COVID-19.

Experience 9 — IC3, Selected Feb 2023 (offer never released due to hiring freeze)

Was selected for an IC3 position about 2 months prior (Feb 2023), but the offer letter was

never released due to a hiring freeze, so eventually gave up on OCI.

Technical Screening Round (In-Depth)

- "Longest Substring Without Repeating Characters."
- Where do you mention env changes in the Helm chart?
- Given a sales table, write a query to output day-wise total sales: `select sum(amount) from sales group by sale_date LIMIT 2`.
- How does a migration file look like inside?
- How to modify a migration file such that some rows contain one set of default values and other rows contain another?
- How do migration dependencies work — e.g. for a `006_ini` file, would only the `005` dependency be listed, or all of `001, 002, 003, 004`? (Answer: only `005` will be there.)
- How do you write an endpoint for an email service?
- How do you do load balancing — which algorithm?
- Write a cron job syntax: `0 * * * *`.
- What states did you use in React? Write the syntax for `useState` and how to update the state.
- Difference between props and state.
- How do you access a DOM element in React?
- Write an `onClick` function.
- Write a Promise.
- Write an Axios POST request.
- How do you pass props from one component to another?
- How do you list databases in the `settings.py` file in Django, and can you declare multiple database instances?
- What is `INSTALLED_APPS` in `settings.py`?
- How do you implement Two-Factor authentication?
- `psql` commands for PostgreSQL — list all tables, connect to a database.
- Have you used Celery? How does Celery work internally?
- Is Axios asynchronous?

Round 1

- Projects done / tech stack / K8s.
- Have you worked with Terraform?
- Tell me a time when you had to learn a new skill.
- What do your daily responsibilities include — how much coding vs team managing?

- What is your biggest professional achievement so far?
- Mutable vs immutable difference.
- When to use a list vs a dictionary vs a tuple.
- How do you measure the time taken for a function in Python? (Imagine you have hundreds of functions.)
- Shallow copy vs deep copy in Python.
- HackerRank coding problem: find finest food outlets.

Round 2

- What is the biggest obstacle you have faced?
- What is the biggest professional achievement so far?
- Architecture for QAHub.
- What do your daily responsibilities include — how much coding vs team managing?
- [System Design] Implement a recommendation system for an online bookstore.

Round 3

- First 30 minutes: grilled on every part of the resume — roles, responsibilities, and contributions at current company.
- Last 30 minutes: HackerRank puzzle problem.

Round 4

- What projects did you do in your current role?
- Difference between `var` and `let`.
- Difference between Angular and React?
- Is React MVC?
- Write JS code to open a URL.
- Write JS code to refresh a page every 30 seconds.
- Given a 4×4 matrix, divide it into 4 equal segments such that each segment is not a square or rectangle, and they should not bisect. Answer: not possible — any partition of a 4×4 matrix into 4 equal parts must result in either 4 squares or 2 rectangles, because the matrix has an equal number of rows and columns, so any equal partition will share rows/columns (squares) or differ (rectangles).
- `data = 1010100` — sort this data.
- Write unit tests.
- Difference between shallow copy and deep copy.
- Which module do you use for unit testing?

- Store username and password in `sessionStorage`, retrieve them, and clear them after 5 minutes.
- `data = "I Like Oracle and Oracle Likes You"` — count the frequency of each word in the string.
- Since you are a UI developer, do you have any personal blogs to show? (Answered: not completely UI, but acts as full stack based on requirements.)

Round 5

- Your React app is taking time to load — how would you troubleshoot it? What performance techniques do you follow? (Answered: open the console, check the performance tab, see how much time static files are taking, and use a CDN to get static files faster.)
 - Let's say CDN storage above 10 MB is costly — how would you handle it? (Answered: use compression algorithms to reduce the size transferred over the network.)
 - CRM dashboard scenario: once a customer call gets connected, the next step is to fetch metadata like personal info, last 5 transactions, account details, etc. — if the agent says "please wait for a minute, your data is loading," that's wasted time for the end user. How would you handle this? (Answered: asynchronously precompute the data as soon as the call connects and store it in an in-memory cache like Redis.)
 - Tell me about a situation where you got work you didn't like, yet had to do it.
 - If there is only frontend work in the team, would you do it?
 - If there's a cool-off period involving monitoring/support kind of work, would you take it as an opportunity and do it?
 - How do you analyse a SQL query that is taking a long time to execute?
 - Design a system where you read log files, raise exceptions, and create a Jira ticket for it. (Edge case: if there are the same exceptions from multiple users, don't create multiple tickets — only raise 1 Jira ticket corresponding to it.)
 - Have you used `useCallback` and `useMemo`?
-

Experience 10 — IC3, Senior Engineer (7 years experience)

Background

- Status: 7 years experience in software development.
- Position: Senior Engineer in a mid-sized Product-Based org.
- Location: Bangalore.
- Recruiter reached out through Instahyre and scheduled a technical screening round after a basic discussion about current roles and responsibilities.

Technical Screening

- Introduction.
- Write REST APIs for an Unbounded Queue (Request Body, API, Verbs, Response Body, etc.).
- Implement an Unbounded Queue — implemented using the `synchronized` keyword, then asked to change it to use Locks & Concurrent interfaces.
- Recruiter informed that the candidate was shortlisted for onsite interviews and scheduled 5 interview rounds over the next 5 days.

Loop 1

- Designing TinyUrl (HLD and LLD both).

Loop 2

- A couple of behavioural questions.
- What happens in the background after hitting enter, after typing www.google.com in the browser?
- How does the browser suggest "google" just after typing "g"? (Asked to implement a Trie.)
- "Two Sum" [LeetCode Easy] — unclear why this was chosen after so much discussion.

Loop 3

- A couple of behavioural questions.
- Different aspects of system design (load balancers, security, API gateway, deployment strategy).
- "House Robber III."

BT Round

- Lots of behavioural questions.

HM Round

- Discussed past project and roles & responsibilities.
- Lots of behavioural questions.

Note: Technical questions were relatively easy; the focus was heavily on behavioural questions.

Experience 11 — Onsite for OCI (Offer received eventually)

Phone Screen

- 1-hour screening round. Started with some questions about past experience. For the next 40 minutes, given a problem to solve (a HackerRank problem). Explained the approach and wrote complete code; the interviewer gave some hints and the code ran successfully.

Loop Rounds (Virtual)

Round 1: Coding round. After initial behavioural questions, given a coding question to solve (a HackerRank question) — solved it. Given one more question and asked the approach only — related to a Graph question.

Round 2: Also a DSA round. Given a question that wasn't solved at first but was cracked after a few hints and discussion. After that, discussed a bit of Designing Principles and approaches.

Round 3: Again a coding round, with a few LP-style questions too. Given a simple coding question, coded it quickly after explaining the thought process. Interviewer then asked some follow-up questions about the code. Overall this round went really well.

Round 4: A bar tender round, mostly behavioural. Interviewer asked many questions regarding past experience and a lot of questions related to Oracle's Leadership Principles. This round also went really well.

Round 5 (HM): Mainly about past project experiences — was really grilled about anything that was said.

Result: Overall experience was really good. Given verbal communication by HR, but it took almost a month to receive the offer. **UPDATE:** Offer letter received; will be joining soon. **Compensation Details:** referenced via an external compensation discussion link (OCI / IC3 / Remote).

Experience 12 — Phone Screen + Loop (Observer Pattern, ML basics)

Phone Screen

- General resume overview.
- Coding Question: given a string, find all the unrepeated characters in the string.
- Observer Pattern; basics of machine learning (as mentioned in resume).

Round 1

- "Minimum Cost to Connect Sticks."
- "Subsets."

Round 2

- "Target Sum."
- "Recover Binary Search Tree."

Round 3

- Given an array of n numbers, initially sorted as 1 to n , where each number can exchange itself with a number to its right. A number can only be switched twice. Find the number of flips that occurred in the array to reach its current state.

Bartender

- Biggest technical challenge faced.
- Time when you went out of your assigned responsibility to maintain a high standard of delivery.
- Time when you disagreed with your peers.
- Roles and responsibilities in current team.
- Working across peer time zones of different time zones.

Hiring Manager

- Questions were similar to the ones asked in the bartender round.
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Experience 13 — SMTS, M.Tech (Feb 2020)

Background

- Status: M.Tech from a Tier 1 institution in India.
- Position: SMTS at Oracle.
- Location: Bangalore, India.
- Date: Feb 2020.
- Approached through LinkedIn for the job profile. There were 5 rounds, all on Zoom calls, each about 40-60 minutes.

Intro / Coderpad Round

- Marking 0 for the entire row i and column j if (i, j) is 0, done in place. Asked to write custom test cases and walk through the code — wrote two additional test cases. (Reference: "Set Matrix Zeroes.")
- Implement a rate-limiting API.

HLD Round

- Started with the current project and was asked questions based on it:
 - Queue-based load leveling for a web server, gateway, and load balancers. Extended the discussion to throttling.
 - Describe one design consideration that was wrong / not considered, and was costly in the long run.
- This round was very interactive — discussed many scenarios and edge cases and possible ways to prevent or circumvent each scenario.

DS and Algo Round

Questions ranged from easy to medium LeetCode difficulty:

- Implement Snake and Ladder, very similar to LeetCode's "Snakes and Ladders" — proposed a DP-based solution.
- Evaluate an expression tree — proposed a stack-based solution to translate the expression into postfix notation and then evaluate it.
- Longest common palindromic substring (reference: "Longest Palindromic Substring").
- Then asked a few LP (Leadership Principle) questions.

Hiring Manager Round

- Mostly about the project and scope of work for the position being hired for, along with a detailed-level discussion on the current project. Deep dive discussion on scalability and availability of the system, plus some LP questions.

Bar Raiser Round with Director

- Design a system at scale (million users).
- Discussion on load balancer, APIM, gateways, consistency models, and how each consistency decision would affect the system.
- A slightly difficult behavioural question involving negative scenarios.

Overall: The entire set of rounds lasted for 3 weeks. The HR coordinator was very helpful during the process.

Tip: Found cloud design patterns discussed on MSDN/Azure Architecture guide very helpful for design discussion and detailed analysis.

Experience 14 — SMTS (IC3), OpenText background — Final Offer ₹62 LPA

Background

- Current Company: OpenText
- Current CTC: ₹18 LPA
- College: Tier-3 (arguably Tier-4)
- Experience: 3 years, 11 months
- Role: SMTS (IC3) at Oracle Cloud Infrastructure (OCI)

Screening Round

- Given two random coding problems on HackerRank, similar to Codeforces A/B level problems — had to be solved with all test cases passing.
- Asked some basic questions on Distributed Systems.
- **Result:** Got a callback within 2 days, informing selection for the onsite loop rounds.

Loop Round 1 — Hiring Manager (HLD + Behavioral)

- This round focused deeply on the current project.
- Asked to draw and explain the system architecture.
- Follow-up questions were around how the system could be improved.
- The last 20–25 minutes focused on behavioural questions.
- Feedback: the hiring manager was quite friendly; everything was explained clearly and he was satisfied.

Loop Round 2 — SMTS (HLD + LLD on HackerRank)

- Started with 5–7 minutes of microservices-related questions.
- Then transitioned into a HackerRank test with 3 design-related questions:
 - **Add to Cart** — given a system design, had to identify bottlenecks and suggest latency improvements.
 - **BookMyShow Design** — asked to design the API, schema, and high-level architecture.
 - **LLD Implementation** — given an interface, had to implement two classes.

- The interviewer didn't engage much — didn't ask any cross-questions, felt more like a monologue.
- Concluded with one behavioural question.
- Feedback: the interview felt long and a bit disconnected due to the lack of interaction.

Loop Round 3 — PMTS (DS + HLD + Behavioral)

- Started with the classic LeetCode question — find the missing number, followed by a variation where multiple numbers could be missing.
- Then moved on to HLD: asked to design a URL Shortener Service.
- Ended with one behavioural question.
- Feedback: this was a smooth interview with good interaction and problem-solving discussion.

Loop Round 4 — Bartender Round (Director of Engineering)

Note: OCI "Bartender Rounds" are conducted by someone from a different team, not related to the one being hired for.

- Started with a detailed discussion on current project and architecture.
- Asked many follow-up and behavioural questions.
- Then came the problem-solving segment: the Josephus Problem. The interviewer was very strict about time: "If you can solve it in the next 10 minutes, great. Otherwise, I'll conclude the interview." Solved it in 6 minutes due to a strong grip on recursion.
- Feedback: the interviewer was a bit stern, but the round was intense and rewarding.

Loop Round 5 — PMTS (USA-based, Technical + Behavioral)

- Started with the project walkthrough.
- Then moved to scenario-based HLD questions.
- Asked 3 behavioural questions.
- Finally given a custom DFS/BFS problem (not on LeetCode) with several tricky edge cases.
- Feedback: managed to solve it successfully — the round was well-balanced between technical depth and behavioural aspects.

Final Result

- Got a call the very next day — selected.

Final Offer:

A Note to Tier-3/Tier-4 College Students and Job Seekers: To all the hard-working folks from Tier-3 or Tier-4 colleges — started career at ₹2.36 LPA. After 2 years of learning and upskilling, moved to OpenText at ₹16 LPA. Now, after another 2 years, landed at OCI with ₹62 LPA. What changed? Not the background — just the effort. The plan now is to mentor others, free of cost, who are in a similar situation, as a way of paying it forward.

Experience 15 — Onsite for OCI (LeetCode Hard screening, 5-hour onsite)

Tech Screen

- 1-hour screening round, started with questions about past experience. For the next 40 minutes, given a problem to solve — it was a LeetCode hard problem. Explained the approach and wrote complete code; interviewer gave some hints and the code ran successfully.

Onsite — 5 hours, with 2 breaks

Round 1: A coding round. After initial behavioural questions, given a coding question — a LeetCode medium (tending toward hard). Solved the question but took the complete time, with no time left for Q&A.

Round 2: A system design round. Started with behavioural questions, then given an ambiguous statement of "Design xyz system." The interviewer was friendly and asked a lot of counter-questions, helping at many points.

Round 3: Again a coding round, with a few LP-style questions too. Given a coding question (LeetCode medium), coded it quickly after explaining the thought process. Interviewer then added another question to it (again LeetCode medium) — explained the approach and coded it. Follow-up questions about the code followed. Overall this round went really well.

Round 4: A bar tender round, mostly behavioural. Interviewer asked many questions regarding past experience. At the end, given a simple problem to solve. This round also went really well.

Round 5: The round with the hiring manager — mainly about past project experiences, really grilled about anything said.

Tips

- Prepare all the Oracle-tagged questions on LeetCode (especially medium & hard).
- Go through all the popular system design questions (if there's no prior design experience).
- Know past projects really well — prepare for all the counter-questions.
- OCI really values its principles — prepare multiple stories about each OCI value.

Comp details: referenced via an external compensation discussion link (OCI / IC3 / Remote).

Experience 16 — OCI Rounds 1-6, plus a Paytm interview loop

OCI

Round 1 (Problem Solving)

- "Minimum Add to Make Parentheses Valid."
- Minimum appends required to make a string palindrome.
- Longest sub-array having sum K.

After Round 1, got a call from HR saying there would be another 5 rounds.

Round 2 (Problem Solving + Design)

- Generate all the permutations of a string ("Permutations").
- System Design: TinyURL.
- How DNS works.

Round 3 (Bartender)

- Discussion about current work.
- Questions related to microservice architecture.
- Lots of behavioural questions (competencies, biggest achievement, any conflict with teammates/manager, etc.).

Round 4 (Problem Solving)

- Internal implementation of HashMap; difference between HashMap and TreeMap; how a custom object can be used as a key.
- Given unlimited eggs and n floors, find the number of trials needed to find the floor at which an egg won't break.
- "Bulb Switcher."
- "Odd Even Linked List."

Round 5 (Technical)

- Discussion about one of the previous projects.
- Concurrency questions: difference between calling `run()` and `start()`, the `synchronized` keyword, how to implement a thread pool.
- How to make a system highly available.
- Write a program to print all the palindromes in a given string.

Round 6 (Hiring Manager)

- Discussion about current work and responsibilities.
- Behavioural questions (biggest technical challenge in recent times, why leaving current company, why Oracle, etc.).
- Details about the team, work, and the role.

Paytm

Round 1 (Problem Solving)

- "Coin Change."
- Prefix Search: given a list of words, get all the words starting with a given prefix.
- "Search in Rotated Sorted Array II."

Round 2 (Design)

- Discussion about current work.
- Design problem: a Search API for an e-commerce website. There is a data lake where unstructured data about all products is populated, updated at the end of each day — containing data about city, productId, number of views, and number of purchases for that particular day. Design an API to show the most popular products of the last n days for a given search term in a given city (e.g. searching for "shoes" should show the most popular such products in the last n days in the current city). Assume a catalog service already provides all productIds for a given search term. How will search work? What will be the structure of the API (Request, Response, Method)?

Round 3 (Java + Spring + LLD)

- Discussion about the architecture and design of the previous project.
- What is dependency injection? How would you implement Spring Dependency Injection? How would you detect a cyclic dependency?
- Internal implementation of HashSet and HashMap.
- LLD of a Parking Lot.

